problem is that algorithms make decisions by relying on numerous data points, whereas humans find it very difficult to consciously reflect on a large number of data points and weigh them against each other. We prefer to work with single data points. That's why when faced by complex issues – whether a loan request, a pandemic or a war – we often seek a single reason to take a particular course of action and ignore all other considerations. This is the fallacy of the single cause.[39]

We are so bad at weighing together many different factors that when people give a large number of reasons for a particular decision, it usually sounds suspicious. Suppose a good friend failed to attend our wedding. If she provides us with a single explanation – 'My mum was in hospital and I had to visit her' – that sounds plausible. But what if she lists fifty different reasons why she decided not to come: 'My mum was a bit under the weather, and I had to take my dog to the vet sometime this week, and I had this project at work, and it was raining, and … and I know none of these fifty reasons *by itself* justifies my absence, but when I added all of them together, they kept me from attending your wedding.' We don't say things like that, because we don't think along such lines. We don't consciously list fifty different reasons in our mind, give each of them a certain weight, aggregate all the weights and thereby reach a conclusion.

But this is precisely how algorithms assess our criminal potential or our creditworthiness. The COMPAS algorithm, for example, made its risk assessments by taking into account the answers to a 137-item questionnaire.[40] The same is true of a bank algorithm that refuses to give us a loan. If the EU's GDPR regulations force the bank to explain the algorithm's decision, the explanation will not come in the shape of a single sentence; rather, it is likely to come in the form of hundreds or even thousands of pages full of numbers and equations.

'Our algorithm,' the imaginary bank letter might read, 'uses a precise points system to evaluate all applications, taking a thousand different types of data points into account. It adds all the data points to reach an overall score. People whose overall score is negative are considered low-credit persons, too risky to be given a loan. Your overall score was −378, which is why your loan application was refused.' The letter might then provide a detailed list of the thousand factors the algorithm took into account, including things that most humans might find irrelevant, such as the exact hour the application was submitted[41] or the type of smartphone the